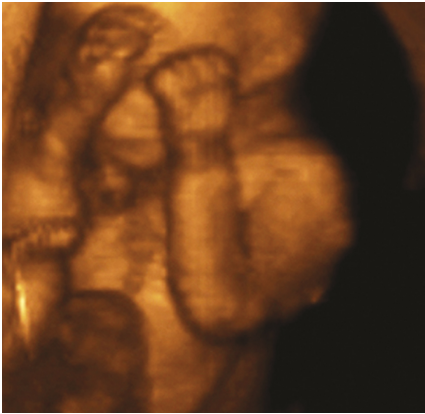




YOU ARE **19 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

141 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

You will become much more aware of your baby moving as her size and strength increase. You will not be aware of the more gentle movements, or those movements that do not hit the side of the uterus.

“You’re likely to experience some backaches as your baby grows in size and your body continually adapts to accommodate.”

The increasing weight of your developing baby, and the fact that your joints and ligaments soften in pregnancy, can cause backaches, but thankfully you don’t just have to put up with this pain. There are many simple ways in which you can ease a backache or even prevent it (see [Banish backaches](#)).

See your doctor to make sure that the problem and its exact location is properly diagnosed. This way you’ll have more chance of stopping it from becoming worse. A common problem, often in later pregnancy, is [sciatica](#)—a sharp pain that travels down the back and leg.

BANISH BACKACHES

To nip backaches in the bud, try the following:

- **Take a warm bath** or use a hot-water bottle on the painful area.
- **Ask your partner** to give you a nice back rub, or get yourself a massage with an experienced prenatal practitioner.
- **Go to yoga or Pilates classes** to strengthen your back muscles.
- **Watch your posture** (see [Pregnancy posture](#)), and raise your legs when seated.
- **Ensure your car seat** is properly positioned to support your back.

FIBROIDS DURING PREGNANCY

In the **second trimester**, fibroids—which are benign masses of muscle fiber within the uterine wall, or occasionally attached to it—can become problematic. Increased levels of the hormones estrogen and progesterone during pregnancy encourage fibroids to grow along with the uterus.

In some circumstances, the rapid growth of a fibroid causes feelings of pressure, discomfort, or pain. Fibroids may increase a woman’s risk of miscarriage, preterm birth, or having a baby in the breech position. Fibroids that do not cause discomfort do not require treatment.

Fibroids will not usually affect the developing baby, but if a large fibroid is positioned low down in the uterus or near to the cervix, it can prevent the baby from descending into the pelvis,